the Chinese leadership. CMC chairman Xi Jinping upbraided the East Sea Fleet leadership for not confirming that the Americans were behind the attack, a point made directly by President Newsom in a nationally televised address on September 23. Xi also concluded that an attack on another US carrier, the *John C. Stennis*, would likely lead the Americans to begin large-scale operations against Chinese land-based missile targets, docks, shipyards, and air bases. With more US ships reaching the theater of battle, it would be harder to control the conflict, and Beijing could wind up losing the gains it had made, namely eliminating the American presence in the South China Sea and taking control of the Taiwan Strait with a Finlandized Taiwan. Xi therefore contacted Newsom on the morning of September 23 and proposed an immediate cease-fire, to be followed by negotiations between military commanders for a permanent halt to combat operations.

Newsom faced a different set of constraints than Xi. With one aircraft carrier gone, the US Navy had only two fully operational carriers left from the total force of nine; it would take weeks to bring two more up to combat readiness and months to get another two ready for deployment. The navy had also deployed the majority of its combat-ready destroyers and submarines, and further losses from missile attacks would begin to seriously degrade the US capability to wage surface war. The US Air Force had outclassed its Chinese opponents, but its number of mission-ready airplanes was declining, as well as its stores of air-to-air missiles. Surging both naval and air units to the region left little in reserve for a longer conflict.

A grim balance had been achieved with the mirror attacks on the aircraft carriers, and Newsom responded positively to Xi's proposal, contingent on the immediate release of all US military personnel held by the Chinese, to which Xi consented, promising that they would be transferred to the Philippines by Chinese ships beginning on September 25. The two agreed that all combat operations would cease at 11:00 Beijing time on September 24, and forces would hold at their positions at the status quo.